

A First Look at Your Project's Size

CS 5388 / CS 4390

Team: Team 7

Project: Festivo Party Planner

Work through every step together as a team. Have your Sprint 1 charter open (scope boundary and stakeholder map) and your interview notes. Everything you write here becomes the starting point for today's user stories and for the two estimates in Part 2.

Step 1. List what Release 1 must do *(as a team)*

Start from the "in scope" items in your charter and the strongest needs from your interviews. Write 5 to 8 capabilities as what the system must do, not how. Then mark the hidden work each one will need using the key below.

Hidden work key: T = Testing S = Security or privacy I = Integration with other systems D = Data (collection, cleaning, migration) H = Hosting and deployment U = Usability and accessibility O = Documentation or training

#	Capability (what, not how)	Evidence (charter or interview)	Hidden work
1	User account creation and authentication.	<i>Phase 2 Party Planner – Interview 2</i>	<i>T, S, U, D</i>
2	Creation of a new party, event, or social gathering	<i>Phase 1 Party Planner – Interview 1</i>	T, U, D
3	Event information including event name, date, time, location, expected number of guests, event type, and estimated budget	<i>Phase 2 Party Planner - Interview 5</i>	T, U, D
4	Search and display of local vendors or service providers	<i>Phase 1 Party Planner – Interview 3</i>	T, U, D
5	Vendor information including business name, services offered, estimated pricing, contact information, location, and availability when accessible	<i>Phase 2 Party Planner - Interview 5</i>	T, U, D, I
6	Ability for the event organizer to update event information	<i>Phase 2 Party Planner – Interview 3</i>	T, U, D
7	Vendor categories including Food & Catering, Entertainment, Tables & Chairs, Decorations, and Venues	<i>Phase 1, Party Planner - Interview 1</i>	T, U
8	Ability to save vendors or services being considered	<i>Phase 1, Party Planner - Interview 1</i>	T, U, D

The example row is from the fictional Campus Parking System used in lecture.

Step 2. Take the outside view: your own experience *(as a team)*

As a team, pick the most similar thing any of you has built before: a class project, internship feature, hackathon app, or side project.

Question	Answer
What was it?	The most similar thing that any of us has built would be an IA/TA/PL UTEP Computer Science web application. The purpose of this project was to make it more intuitive for both professors and

Question	Answer
	students to review/apply towards an IA/TA/PL position for a course that they have taken and passed. This included features such as scheduling applications, reviews, and courses. The professor's interface allowed students to view students schedules or past courses they have taken to then decide on a final decision of their application. Once whatever status it is for the student's application, on their interface they would be up to date on the status that would be either 'pending', 'approved', or 'declined'.
How long was it expected to take?	It was a summer semester group project with many small deadlines and sprints in between. If a set amount of time is to be given, it would be roughly 2-3 months.
How long did it take?	The overall time for that group of people to complete the project was at least two months.
What took longer than expected?	What took longer for that group was implementing the functionality of being able to update schedules of students among each change in both professor and student interfaces. That roughly took almost 15 day's to have a working version where it would not override or prompt errors on the development version.

Step 3. Take the outside view: similar products *(as a team, web search)*

Divide the searching, then decide together. Find three real products that solve a problem close to yours. Include at least one small product (a startup or an app from a small team) and at least one big product (a large company platform or a government system). For each, find out how long it took to reach its first public release, what went well, and what went wrong.

How to find the timeline and the story

1. Launch announcements, company blogs, and founder interviews often say when building started and when the product first went public.
2. Press coverage, app store version histories, and the Internet Archive's Wayback Machine help confirm first release dates.
3. Postmortems, conference talks, and, for government systems, GAO and Inspector General reports explain what worked and what did not.
4. Measure from the start of development to the first public release and write down what that first release included. A limited first version and a full launch are different numbers.
5. Every date and figure needs a source you can link. If you cannot find one, write "unknown." AI tools may suggest products to look at, but they are not a source.

Example: a completed entry for a parking product

ParkEasy is fictional. It shows the level of detail to aim for, not real data.

Field	Entry
Product and company	ParkEasy, a four-person startup
Why it is similar	Drivers find and pay for parking from a phone, like our Campus Parking System.
Development started	January 2019 (founder blog post)
First public release	October 2019, in one city only (local news launch story)
Time to first release	About 9 months
What the first release included	A map of open lots and pay-by-phone. No reservations and no monthly permits.
Team size	Three engineers and one designer
What worked	Launching in one city first. Partnering with a single lot operator to get reliable availability data.
What did not work	Their own parking sensors gave bad availability data, so they switched to the operator's feed, adding about 3 months. Payment integration took twice as long as planned.
Sources	Founder blog post (link); local news launch story (link)

What this example tells a team building a parking app: plan for data and payment integration to take the longest, and scope the first release to one location.

Step 3 worksheet: similar products

	Product A (small)	Product B (big)	Product C (your choice)
Product and company	Hooray! Party Planner	TimeTree	Partiful
Why it is similar to your project	A party planning app that lets you organize and invite people to an event. It also lets you rate the event afterwards.	The app has to do with event planning and scheduling. It also has a social aspect in terms of sharing schedules and calendars.	An event planning and management platform, send RSVP and updates to users
Development started	June 30, 2023	Founded September 1, 2024 (estimate of development estimate from company funding to release).	2022 (funding secured)
First public release	July 4, 2024	March 19, 2025	May 12, 2024
Time to first release	370 days	199 days.	~2 years, 5 months, 12 days – 2 years
What the first release included	Party/event organization with digital invitations, RSVPs, checklists, and budget planning.	Shared calendars for couples, families, and friends. Invitations to shared calendars; event creation.	Customizable event pages, RSVP Tracking, the ability to send text reminders, contact syncing
Team size, if known	Not publicly disclosed.	Small startup team.	~30
What worked	The app combines several party planning functions in one place, including inviting, RSVP, tracking and budgeting.	Focus on calendar sharing rather than individual scheduling. The company reached 1 million registered users within 10 months.	Focused primarily on one issue of party planning, made sending invites both interesting and easy. Compressed event scheduling/updates into a single event page users could view with a link
What did not work	Extremely buggy, lack of reliability, and usability errors. Google reviews report problems creating events, and event type drop downs which won't populate.	Release took longer than expected as quality did not reach expectations until months later.	User complain that certain hosts can abuse the Text Notification feature to spam users with texts, there's a lack of a gift registry feature only payment processing (which other services do have), reviews complain about the aggressiveness the app asks for your contact list, lots of complaints about crashing
Sources (links)	- https://play.google.com/store/apps/details?id=com.hooray&hl=en_US	- https://timetreeapp.com/ntl/ja/newsroom/2020-05-	- https://play.google.com/store/apps/details?id=com.partiful.partiful&%24web_only=true

	Product A (small)	Product B (big)	Product C (your choice)
		13/history?utm_source=chatgpt.com - https://play.google.com/store/apps/details?id=works.jubilee.timetree&hl=en_US	- https://apps.apple.com/us/app/partiful-party-invite-maker/id1662982304 - https://partiful.com/

Step 4. Compare *(as a team)*

1. Look at the hidden-work column in Step 1. Which letter appears most often? Did any of your similar products struggle with that same kind of work?

T for testing and U for usability. Yes, Hooray! Party Planner struggled with usability errors with users reporting multiple bugs with critical features. This also indicates lack of sufficient testing of those critical features.

2. How long did your similar products take to reach a first release, and with how many people? What does that suggest about a first release of your project?

Our similar projects took anywhere from about 6 months to 2 years to reach their first releases. Team sizes varied from small startup team to around 30 people. This suggests that our first release should focus on the main features of Festivo instead of trying to include every possible feature on once.

3. Name one practice from the “what worked” rows your team will copy, and one mistake from the “what did not work” rows you will avoid.

Hooray! Party Planner worked well by combining several party planning functions in one place, including inviting, RSVP, tracking and budgeting. The other apps had buggy launches that caused users to be annoyed, what we can do is do extensive testing to make sure our product comes out as concise as it can be. We also want to avoid any abuse of our social features, such as in Partiful where some users felt hosts could abuse the text notification feature to spam their messages

Our comparables suggest a first release would take 7 to 14 months with a team of 5.

Keep this sheet. You will use Step 1 to write user stories, and Steps 2 and 3 give you comparators for analogous estimation in Part 2.